

How to Choose Your Wedding Photographer in Austin.

A guide from 18 years of Austin wedding photography.

What to look for, what to ask, and what to avoid.

- Start with style — editorial vs. posed vs. everything else.
- Experience, consistency, and what 18 years actually means.
- The photographer question — who is actually showing up.
- What to look for in a portfolio.
- Questions to ask before you book.
- How to think about the investment.
- Red flags — what to walk away from.

NYDAM PHOTOGRAPHY

“Genuine. Intentional. Timeless.”

nydamphoto.com · Austin, Texas · Est. 2008

A NOTE BEFORE YOU START

This Is the Most *Important Vendor Decision.*

The food gets eaten. The flowers fade. The dress goes into storage.
The photographs are what remain.

*“You will look at your wedding photographs more than you will look
at any other object you own. Choose accordingly.”*

NYDAM PHOTOGRAPHY

Most couples spend more time choosing their cake than their photographer. And then they live with the photographs forever. This guide exists to change that — to give you a clear framework for making one of the most consequential decisions of your wedding planning.

This is not a neutral guide. It is written by a photographer with 18 years of Austin weddings, and it reflects what we genuinely believe makes the difference between images you love and images that just exist. We will tell you what to look for. We will tell you what questions to ask. And we will tell you what to walk away from.

If you read this and decide Nydam Photography is the right fit for your wedding — wonderful. If you read this and make a better decision elsewhere — that is equally the goal. The wedding photography market in Austin is large. The number of photographers who will still matter to you in twenty years is small. This guide helps you find one.

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01

Start With Style.

Before budget, before availability, before anything else — get clear on what kind of images you actually want to live with. Wedding photography has distinct styles. They are not interchangeable. Choosing the wrong one is the most common and most permanent mistake couples make.

THE STYLES — WHAT THEY ACTUALLY MEAN

+ Editorial.

Images composed with the intentionality of editorial photography — publication-quality framing, deliberate light, considered composition. Not posed in the traditional sense, but directed with intention. The result looks natural and cinematic simultaneously. This is the style that ages best.

+ Photojournalistic.

Candid coverage that prioritizes capturing events as they happen without intervention. Pure reaction, pure emotion, no staging. The strongest wedding photographers combine this with editorial direction — knowing when to stay invisible and when to guide.

+ Cinematic.

A visual aesthetic that references film — color treatment, lighting ratios, and composition that feel like frames from a feature film. Can be combined with editorial and photojournalistic approaches. Describes a look, not a methodology.

+ Posed / traditional.

Formally directed portraits where couples are placed in specific positions. Produces consistent, predictable results. Requires significant time and produces images that can feel staged. Better for portraits, harder to extend to candid coverage.

+ Light and airy.

A processing aesthetic characterized by high exposure, low contrast, and pale, desaturated tones. Extremely popular on Instagram, particularly with younger photographers. Dates quickly. Images from 2018 already look dated. Ask yourself how these will look in 2040.

+ Dark and moody.

A processing aesthetic with heavy shadows, high contrast, and cool or desaturated tones. The opposite extreme from light and airy. Also dates quickly as a trend aesthetic. Ask the same question.

THE QUESTION TO ASK YOURSELF

*Pull up your ten favorite wedding images from anywhere. What do they have in common?
That is your style. Find a photographer who shoots it consistently.*

STYLE RULE — Trend aesthetics date. Editorial, photojournalistic, cinematic — these hold.

02

Experience & Consistency.

Years in business is a number. What it represents is the ability to perform under pressure, in bad light, on difficult timelines, with unexpected obstacles — and still deliver images worth keeping forever.

WHAT EXPERIENCE ACTUALLY MEANS

+ 18 years means 18 years of problems solved.

A photographer with 18 years of weddings has encountered every possible lighting situation, timeline collapse, venue restriction, and weather condition. They know the solution before the problem fully develops. A photographer with two years of weddings is still discovering them.

+ Consistency across different conditions.

The easiest thing in photography is producing good images in beautiful light at a well-organized venue. The measure of a photographer is what they produce in a dark church, a reception hall with fluorescent lights, or a ceremony that runs 45 minutes over schedule.

+ Consistency across an entire gallery.

Ask to see a full wedding gallery — not 20 hero images. Hero images tell you what a photographer can do on their best shot. A full gallery tells you what you will actually receive. Look for 200+ images that are all at the same level of quality.

+ Local knowledge matters.

A photographer who has shot at your Austin venue before arrives knowing the light at 4pm in October, where the ceremony coordinator wants everyone positioned, and which corner of the ballroom has the cleanest background for portraits. That knowledge shows in the images.

+ Relationships with vendors.

An experienced Austin photographer knows your coordinator, has worked with your florist, and understands how your venue runs. Those relationships produce a smoother day and better images. Ask who they've worked with.

+ Awards and publications — context.

Published work and industry recognition are signals, not requirements. More important: is the work consistent? A photographer with one spectacular published image and an uneven portfolio is a different proposition from a photographer with 18 years of reliable, excellent work.

03

The Photographer Question.

This is the question most couples do not think to ask — and the one that matters most: who is actually going to be at my wedding?

THE AGENCY PROBLEM

A significant portion of the wedding photography market operates as agencies: a brand name with a portfolio, backed by a rotating roster of photographers who may or may not be the person whose work you fell in love with. You book the brand. An associate shows up. The work is often good. It is almost never what you saw in the portfolio.

WHAT TO ASK

Ask directly: “If I book you, who will be at my wedding?” If the answer involves associates, backup photographers, or “it depends on the date,” you are booking an agency. If the answer is a specific person whose work you can see in full galleries from multiple weddings — that is what you are buying.

WHY THIS MATTERS FOR YOUR WEDDING

Photography is a relationship. The images you get are a direct product of how comfortable you are with the person holding the camera. That comfort builds over the months of planning together, through the engagement session, through the pre-wedding communication. It cannot be transferred to a different person on your wedding day.

THE SECOND PHOTOGRAPHER QUESTION

A second photographer is not the same as an associate. A second shooter works alongside the primary photographer — a different angle, a different moment, a wider coverage. Ask who provides second shooting and whether they have worked with the primary photographer before. A first-time team produces first-time-team results.

WHAT NYDAM PHOTOGRAPHY DOES

When you book Nydam Photography, you book our team directly. He is at every wedding. He photographs every session. He makes every creative decision. Tanya coordinates and provides second-camera coverage on wedding days. There are no substitutes, no associates, no surprises. The work you see in the portfolio is the work you will receive.

“The right photographer changes the experience, not just the images.”

04

Reading a Portfolio.

Most couples look at a portfolio the wrong way. They look for beautiful images. The right question is: are these images consistently excellent, or are there ten great ones hidden among hundreds of average ones?

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

+ Ask for a full wedding gallery.

Hero portfolios are curated from thousands of images across years. A full wedding gallery from one day tells you what the average image looks like, not the best one. Any photographer worth booking will show you a full gallery on request.

+ Look at the light across different venues.

Check images from indoor ceremonies, outdoor ceremonies, dark reception halls, and midday outdoor portraits. A photographer who only looks good in golden hour outdoor settings is not prepared for your wedding day.

+ Look at the expressions.

Are the people in the images genuinely present, or are they performing for the camera? Genuine expression is the hardest thing to produce consistently. It is also the thing you will look for in your own images forever.

+ Look at the in-between moments.

The standard shots — first kiss, first dance, ring exchange — are the easiest to get right. What happens between them reveals the photographer's instincts. Look for images that shouldn't exist — the quiet glance, the grandmother's expression, the flower girl mid-thought.

+ Look at the consistency of editing.

Images from the same wedding should look like they belong together. Wildly varying color treatment, exposure, and contrast within a gallery signals either rushed editing or an unsettled aesthetic. Both are problems.

+ Look at images of people like you.

If you are having a large Catholic ceremony, look for galleries from large Catholic ceremonies. If your venue is an outdoor Hill Country ranch, look for Hill Country work. Every venue type and ceremony format requires different skills.

+ Instagram is a highlight reel.

Social media shows a photographer's best 1% across months or years. It is useful for discovering style. It is not useful for assessing consistency. Always ask for full galleries in addition to portfolio review.

+ Reviews across platforms.

Read Google, WeddingWire, and The Knot reviews together. Look for patterns: communication, timeline management, how the photographer handled problems. One negative review with a pattern of positive ones tells a different story than one positive review surrounded by nothing.

05

Questions to Ask Before You Book.

Bring these to every consultation. The answers reveal experience, communication style, and whether this photographer has thought carefully about your specific day.

THE QUESTIONS

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| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> + Will you personally be at my wedding?
Non-negotiable. The answer should be an unqualified yes, with a clear plan for backup if a genuine emergency occurs. + Can I see a full gallery from a recent wedding at my venue — or a similar venue?
Tells you what a full delivery looks like, and whether they know how to work in your specific environment. + How do you handle low light — dark churches, indoor receptions?
An experienced photographer has a specific answer about flash technique, lighting equipment, and approach. A vague answer about “natural light” is a red flag. + What is your backup plan if something happens to you?
Every professional has one. It should involve a specific person, not “I’ll find someone.” + How do you work with our coordinator?
Good photographers have a relationship with the planning community. Ask specifically about your coordinator if they have one assigned. + What does your editing process look like? How long?
You are looking for a consistent answer: specific turnaround, specific number of edited images, clear delivery method. | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> + How many weddings have you shot at my venue?
Venue familiarity matters. Even one prior experience means arriving knowing the light, the layout, and the staff. + What happens if my timeline runs late?
This always happens. A good answer acknowledges it and describes how they prioritize and adapt. An answer that suggests it won’t happen is not reassuring. + What do you need from us to do your best work?
This question reveals how a photographer thinks about the relationship. Good photographers have specific answers. Great photographers have thought about your specific day. + Can we do an engagement session before the wedding?
An engagement session is not just about engagement images. It’s the session where you learn to work together so your wedding day portraits start from familiarity, not introduction. + How do you handle family formals?
Family portraits are logistically the most challenging part of the day. Ask specifically how they manage the list, the timing, and the coordination. A clear system here signals experience. + What do you love about wedding photography?
Not a trick question. The answer tells you whether you are talking to someone who genuinely cares about this work or someone who photographs weddings as a business. |
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06 + 07

The Investment & Red Flags.

How to think about pricing — and what to walk away from.

THE INVESTMENT

- + **The cheapest option is rarely the cheapest outcome.**
A \$1,200 photographer and a \$4,500 photographer produce different work. Not always — but consistently. The question is not what photography costs. It is what you will think about the decision in ten years.
- + **What you are actually paying for.**
You are paying for years of experience, quality equipment, professional editing, a reliable process, and the specific skill of making you look like yourself on the hardest, most watched day of your life. That is not a commodity.
- + **Collections vs. à la carte.**
Collections are designed to cover a full wedding day completely. À la carte pricing requires you to make decisions about coverage while planning a wedding. Collections are simpler. What matters is whether the collection matches your actual day.
- + **The retainer.**
A non-refundable retainer holds your date. It also reflects the photographer's commitment to you. A photographer who does not require a retainer is a photographer who may not show up.

RED FLAGS — WALK AWAY

- + **No contract.**
A professional photographer always has a contract. It protects both parties. The absence of a contract is the absence of professionalism.
- + **Portfolio does not match what arrives.**
If the images you fall in love with are credited to a named photographer but you are being assigned someone else — walk away.
- + **Vague on equipment and backup.**
Professional photographers own professional equipment and have backup bodies, lenses, and cards at every wedding. Vagueness here is a technical red flag.
- + **No response within 48 hours.**
Communication quality before the wedding is a direct predictor of communication quality during it. A photographer who takes days to respond to an inquiry will take days to respond to an urgent question in October.
- + **Cannot show a full gallery on request.**
Every legitimate wedding photographer can show full galleries. The inability or unwillingness to do so means the full work does not match the portfolio.
- + **Peer pressure to book immediately.**
Your date may genuinely be limited. But pressure tactics in a sales conversation are a preview of how decisions will be made throughout the relationship.

About Nydam Photography.

We have been photographing Austin families, seniors, couples, and milestones since 2008. Every session we do is personal. We arrive prepared — every session planned with intention — and we create something real.

We photograph with natural light and flash — almost always, even outdoors — because the quality of the image matters more than the convenience of the approach. Every image is considered. Every detail is intentional.

GENUINE

Every portrait should feel like you — not a polished version of someone else. We create the conditions for real moments, then capture them.

INTENTIONAL

Light, posing, expression, timing — every element of a great portrait is considered in advance and guided with care throughout.

TIMELESS

We edit for longevity, not for trends. The images we create together are meant to stop you in your tracks ten years from now.

Weddings · Families & Portraits · Seniors · Sacraments · Quinceañeras · Events · Sports · Corporate Headshots & Branding

Every specialty. One standard of care.

KNOW SOMEONE WHO DESERVES THIS?

Pass this guide along — or send them directly to us. The right photographer changes everything. If you found yours — share that gift. A referral from a client is the highest compliment we receive.

With warmth,

Arlen and Tanya Nydam, Nydam Photography

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